

his colleague Venkiah Naidu, never at a loss for alliterations or creating a new acronym, dubbed the CBI, the Congress Bureau of Investigation. What could have also helped Mayawati see the Congress point of view is the rather unusual rapport between Law Minister Veerappa Moily and the queen of the cowbelt, Mayawati.

Coalition Compulsions and MINIMUM SUPPORT PRICE

Nothing brings forth the starkness of compromise more than the Mayawati-Congress bonhomie camouflaged by the fig leaf of fighting communalism. Barely a fortnight back, Mayawati had been trading charges with Rahul Gandhi on his pro-Dalit initiatives, calling them a sham. The Congress retaliated, charging her with promoting her cause and neglecting the cause of the oppressed. Now, the team managing the agenda and itinerary of the heir apparent has redrawn his travel plans.

Suddenly from touring Dalit pockets, his office has announced that he now plans to visit the Red corridor of Uttar Pradesh, the Sonbhadra and Chandauli districts. His new-found ally deserves a reciprocal bout of goodwill, fragile as the truce may be. Already Congress spokesman Manish Tiwari is on the defensive. "State politics has its own dynamics," he says, claiming that the Congress will still take on Mayawati in the state.

The dynamics of running a Central government however are much more complicated than issuing glib press releases. The compulsions of allies management do restrict the Prime Minister in following his own agenda of governance. His dilemma is best demonstrated by following the rather tenuous link between his pet Nuclear Liability Bill and the Kolkata municipal elections. The elections are due in May this year and Trinamool's Mamata Banerjee is negotiating tough with the Congress state unit for a large

THE CONGRESS with 207 MPs, its largest tally in nearly two decades, was expected to push through critical reforms and not get bogged down in issues of survival.

The Uncivil WARS

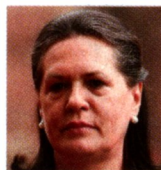


Lack of Attendance

MANMOHAN SINGH
M.K. AZHAGIRI

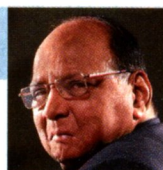


The BJP has often stalled parliament over the minister's frequent absence but there is little the prime minister can do to ensure his attendance.



Food Price Inflation

SONIA GANDHI
SHARAD PAWAR



The cwc found fault with Pawar's handling of spiralling food prices. He retorted that this was a "collective responsibility" of the Cabinet.



Handling of Naxals

DIGVIJAY SINGH
P. CHIDAMBARAM



Singh attacked the home ministry's Naxal policies and also the minister for being "intellectually arrogant".



Anti-Maoist Operations

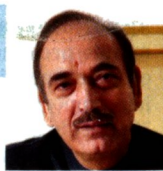
MAMATA BANERJEE
P. CHIDAMBARAM



Mamata said that the Minister's anti-Maoist operations in her state were "providing oxygen" to the CPM.

Amnesty to Militants

GHULAM NABI AZAD
P. CHIDAMBARAM



Azad and Chidambaram differed over J&K Government's plan of amnesty to militants from POK.